

CAR-04 · CAREER ROADMAP

Planner to planning manager

What is owned at each rung of the planning ladder, and why
defending a programme is a different job from maintaining one

VERSION 1.0 · DRAFT

2026-08-04

PROJECT CONTROLS INSTITUTE GLOBAL, INC.

AI proposes. The professional disposes.

— Summary

The planning and scheduling ladder described by what each rung owns — the work, the artefacts, the decisions trusted, and what must be demonstrated to leave. Its centre is the transition that stalls most planning careers: moving from maintaining the programme to defending it, which means being able to explain every movement between updates in causes rather than in dates, and keeping the record that makes the explanation checkable.

— About this document

Document	CAR-04
Series	Career Roadmap
Version	1.0
Status	draft
Date	2026-08-04
Unresolved placeholders	0

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Planner to planning manager

In one paragraph. A programme is used for three different purposes — to sequence work, to measure progress, and to prove entitlement — and most planners are trained for the first while ultimately being judged on the third. This document sets out the planning ladder as a sequence of custodies: at each rung, the work, the artefacts owned, the decisions trusted, and what must be demonstrated to leave. Its centre is the transition that stalls planning careers, from maintaining the programme to defending it, and it gives the specific habit that makes the transition visible: a written delta narrative, every update, explaining movement in causes rather than dates.

Who this is for. Schedulers, planners, planning engineers, lead planners and planning managers, and the project controls managers who develop them; also cost professionals who need to interrogate a programme rather than accept it.

— 1. Three jobs the same programme has to do

The programme is the only artefact in project controls that is simultaneously an operational instrument, a measurement baseline and a piece of evidence.

To sequence work. The delivery team needs to know what happens next, in what order, with what resources. This use rewards detail, currency and readability.

To measure progress. Earned value, the s-curve and the forecast all depend on the programme's activity structure and its link to the cost breakdown. This use rewards stability, consistent coding and disciplined data dates.

To prove entitlement. When a project is delayed, the programme and its update history become the factual record from which cause and effect are argued. This use rewards logic that reflects real constraint, updates that were not retrospectively edited, and a narrative written at the time.

These three uses conflict. Detail helps the first and harms the second. Re-sequencing to help the delivery team can destroy the evidence needed by the third. Recognising and managing the conflict is what distinguishes the upper rungs of this ladder; the failure to recognise it is what produces a programme that is popular on site and useless in a dispute.

— 2. Rung one — scheduler, assistant planner

The work. Collecting actual start and finish dates; recording progress against activities; maintaining the short-term lookahead; producing the s-curve and the standard reporting outputs; keeping the activity coding correct; distributing the update.

Artefacts owned. The progress update file. The lookahead. The s-curve and the standard report outputs. The record of what was reported by whom.

Decisions trusted. Whether a reported percentage is credible against what the lookahead said would happen. Whether an activity is genuinely started or merely mobilised. Whether the update is complete enough to run.

What must be demonstrated to leave. That the update is right, on time and reproducible — and that you challenge implausible progress rather than entering it. The signal is a scheduler who returns to a supervisor with "you reported 60 % last period and 62 % now, but the lookahead had this activity finishing; what changed?" That question is the beginning of planning.

The trap. Becoming the person who operates the software. Tool fluency is assumed everywhere above this rung and distinguishes nobody.

— 3. Rung two — planning engineer

The work. Ownership of a section of the programme: building the logic, agreeing durations with the people who will perform the work, mapping activities to the work breakdown structure and to cost, running the update including the decisions the software cannot make, and writing the variance-to-baseline narrative for that section.

Artefacts owned. The section's logic and durations, with the basis on which each was agreed. The update package. The schedule health metrics for the section — open ends, constraints, negative lag, out-of-sequence progress, excessive durations ([BPG-05 – Schedule quality](#) owns the metric set). The section's variance narrative.

Decisions trusted. Whether to accept a subcontractor's declared duration or challenge it, and on what evidence. Whether progress that occurred out of sequence should be handled by retained logic or progress override, which changes the answer the programme gives. Whether an apparent recovery is real or an artefact of how the update was run. Whether to re-sequence or to report the slippage.

What must be demonstrated to leave. That you can explain the section's movement between two updates in causes, and that the explanation is supported by the record. This is the beginning of the transition in §6.

The trap. Accepting durations because they were given by someone senior or by a subcontractor with an interest in them. A duration accepted without a basis becomes, three updates later, a date you cannot defend and did not choose.

— 4. Rung three — senior planner, lead planner

The work. Ownership of the integrated programme: all sections, all interfaces, all contributors, including the subcontractor programmes that must be accepted or rejected. Ownership of the baseline and its change control. Running quantitative schedule risk analysis (QSRA) and interpreting it. Choosing the delay analysis approach when time becomes contested, and working with the commercial team on notices and entitlement.

Artefacts owned. The integrated baseline and the baseline change log. The driving-path narrative each period. The QSRA model, its input basis and its outputs ([BPG-17](#) owns the technique). The schedule specification applied to subcontractor programmes. The evidence set: dated, unaltered update files.

Decisions trusted. What the critical path actually is when the software's answer is an artefact of a constraint or a calendar. When a rebaseline is legitimate and when it would erase the evidence of delay — one of the most consequential judgements in the function. What float is real and who owns it under the contract. When to escalate a date movement rather than absorb it in the lookahead.

What must be demonstrated to leave. That the programme has survived challenge — from a client, an auditor, a subcontractor or a claim — and that the record supported it. This is the rung where planning becomes a legal-adjacent discipline, and the evidence is documentary.

The trap. Logic churn. Changing links between updates to make the answer look sensible destroys comparability, and comparability is the whole basis of a delay argument. If the logic must change, it changes as a recorded, reasoned amendment, not silently.

— 5. Rung four — planning manager

The work. Ownership of the planning function: the schedule specification and level-of-detail standard, the calendars and coding structures, the update procedure and its cut-off, the tooling, the assurance regime that tests compliance, and the contractual position of the programme itself. Developing planners. Negotiating what the programme is contractually required to be, and resisting requirements that would make it unusable.

Artefacts owned. The schedule specification and planning procedure. The coding and calendar standards. The update calendar and its cut-off. The assurance and health-check regime. The subcontractor programme acceptance criteria. The function's competency and succession position.

Decisions trusted. The level of detail the programme will be built to — the decision that determines whether it can serve all three purposes in §1. Who may change logic, and under what record. What is submitted contractually and what is retained as internal working. Whether to accept a client-imposed schedule requirement, and what to say when it is unworkable.

What must be demonstrated. That an update produced in your absence is defensible. Same test as the cost ladder in [CAR-03](#) §5, and the same failure if you remain the best planner on the project rather than the person who made good planning reproducible.

— 6. The transition that actually blocks people

Between rung two and rung three sits the change nobody names: **from maintaining the programme to defending it.**

Maintaining is running the cycle correctly — statusing, recalculating, distributing. Defending is being able to answer, from the record, why the programme says what it says. Four capabilities separate them.

Every driving link has a reason you can state. Not "that is how it was built". A defensible logic tie reflects a physical, contractual or resource constraint that someone can be named for. Planners who inherit a programme and never interrogate its logic are defending someone else's assertions.

Movement is explained in causes, not in dates. "Completion has moved out by three weeks" is a measurement. "Completion has moved out by fifteen working days because containment installation is achieving 22 m per working day against a planned 30, and the remaining quantity at the achieved rate takes fifteen days longer than the baseline allowed" is a defence — and §9 works that

case through. The instrument is a written delta narrative attached to every update: what moved, by how much, driven by what, and what would reverse it.

The record is unaltered and dated. Every update file retained as issued, never overwritten; the narrative written at the time, not reconstructed. The value of a contemporaneous record is that it was written before anyone knew which way the dispute would go, and that value is destroyed by a single retrospective edit.

You separate the measurement from the promise. A programme that shows recovery contains a promise someone must keep. If you report recovery because a delivery manager asserted it, you have made their promise on your document. Defending means the recovery is either evidenced by an achieved rate or labelled as an assumption with a named owner and a date by which it must be visible.

The reason this transition blocks people is that maintaining is measurable and defending is not — until the moment it is tested, at which point it is the only thing that matters. As with the cost ladder, the route through is to do it before you are asked: write the delta narrative every update, whether or not anyone reads it, and keep it.

— 7. Working with cost, and why it doubles your value

The programme and the cost position describe the same project and are usually produced by different people using different structures. Two things follow.

A planner who understands earned value can tell whether a schedule movement should have a cost consequence and whether the reported cost position reflects it. A planner who cannot will be surprised when the cost team forecasts an overrun that the programme said nothing about.

More practically, the integration point is the control account. If the activity structure does not map cleanly to the cost breakdown, every reconciliation between programme and cost becomes manual, opinionated and slow. That mapping is a rung-three and rung-four decision, and it is where planners have the largest effect on the quality of everything else the function produces.

— 8. How this goes wrong

Detail as a substitute for logic. A programme with tens of thousands of activities and no defensible driving path is harder to maintain and no more credible. Level of detail should be set by what must be measured and controlled, not by what can be listed.

Constraints used to hold dates. Applying a constraint to make an activity report the required date suppresses the very signal the programme exists to give. The date is met on paper and the delay is discovered when it is too late to mitigate.

Rebaselining to make the variance disappear. A rebaseline is legitimate when scope or an approved change makes the old baseline meaningless. It is illegitimate when its purpose is to reset the variance, and it is close to fatal when time is contested, because it removes the reference against which delay would have been measured.

Progress override applied without thought. Out-of-sequence progress handled by the wrong setting can transform the critical path and the completion date without anyone deciding anything. This is a judgement, made every update, and it must be recorded.

Accepting the subcontractor's programme unexamined. An unexamined subcontract programme imports its optimism and its missing interfaces into your integrated model, and you inherit both.

Writing the narrative after the outcome is known. Reconstructed narratives are recognisable and they destroy credibility precisely when it is needed. Write it at the update, before you know what happens next.

— 9. Worked example — defending a movement between two updates

Illustrative figures. One driving activity, cable containment installation, on a project with a five-day working week. Assumptions: the installation is the sole driver of the completion date; the planned rate is the rate used to build the baseline duration; no scope change occurred in the period; the period between update 7 and update 8 is 20 working days.

Position at update 7. Remaining quantity 1,200 m. Planned rate 30 m per working day. Remaining duration = $1,200 \div 30 = 40$ working days.

What the plan implied for the period. 20 working days $\times$ 30 m = **600 m** installed, leaving 600 m and 20 working days remaining at update 8.

What actually happened. 440 m installed in 20 working days. Achieved rate = $440 \div 20 = 22$ m per working day. Remaining quantity = $1,200 - 440 = 760$ m.

Two defensible remaining durations, and they differ by nine days. Assuming the planned rate is recovered: $760 \div 30 = 25.3 \rightarrow 26$ working days, which is 6 days more than the 20 the plan implied. Assuming the achieved rate persists: $760 \div 22 = 34.5 \rightarrow 35$ working days, which is 15 days more than planned. Difference between the two positions = $35 - 26 = 9$ working days.

The plausibility test that turns a choice into a defence. To finish in the 20 working days the baseline still shows as remaining, the crew would have to achieve $760 \div 20 = 38$ m per working day — that is $38 \div 30 = 1.267$, or **26.7 % above the planned rate**, and $38 \div 22 = 1.727$, or **72.7 % above the rate actually being achieved**. Nobody has yet demonstrated the planned rate, let alone a quarter more than it.

The defence. Report 35 working days remaining and 15 days of movement; state the mechanism — the achieved rate is 22 against a planned 30, evidenced in both the installed quantity record and the timesheets; state the recovery condition — a second crew, or release of the two areas currently permit restricted, would raise the achievable rate, and the required rate to recover fully is 38 m per day, which is above anything demonstrated on this project; and state the test — the achieved rate will be reported against 30 every update, and if it has not exceeded 30 within two updates of the areas being released, the recovery assumption is withdrawn.

If instead you report 26 days because a delivery manager has committed to recovery, you have not made a forecast. You have signed someone else's promise, on your document, and it is your credibility that is spent when it is not kept.

— 10. Checklist — evidence that you are at the next rung already

- You attach a written delta narrative to every update, explaining movement in causes, and you keep the narratives.
- You can name the physical, contractual or resource reason for every link on the current driving path.
- You retain every issued update file unaltered, and you can produce the set for any period on request.
- You have rejected or challenged a declared duration or a reported percentage and been right.
- You have run the plausibility test in §9 on a recovery claim, in writing, before agreeing to show it.
- You have recorded an out-of-sequence judgement — retained logic or progress override — and its effect on the completion date.
- You can explain the mapping between your activity structure and the cost breakdown structure, and you know where it breaks.
- You have told a project director that a date has moved before they heard it from anyone else.

A planner whose updates are correct but whose movements are unexplained is discovered in the first contested month, usually by someone external, and by then the record that would have defended them was never written.

— Related

- [CAR-01 – The project controls career roadmap](#) — where this ladder sits in the whole function
- [CAR-03 – Cost engineer to cost manager](#) — the parallel ladder and its own blocking transition
- [CAR-05 – Into project controls leadership](#) — what rung four leads to
- [CAR-07 – Building a portfolio of evidence](#) — how to capture the update record described in §6
- [BPG-05 – Schedule quality: a practical review](#) — the metric set referenced at rung two
- [BPG-12 – Claims and extension of time](#) — where the evidential use of the programme is treated in full
- [BPG-17 – Quantitative schedule risk analysis](#) — the technique owned at rung three

— Sources and standards

Drawn from the PCI Body of Knowledge, principally Domain 6 (earned value management and forecasting), Domain 8 (project management lifecycle), Domain 10 (project scheduling) and Domain 12 (risk management for project controls); and from the PCL-AI competency set. Scheduling and delay concepts are described in the Institute's own words; no protected standard text, table or diagram is reproduced. No pay, market or demand data has been used.

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